

FREE DOWNLOAD

The Engagement *Posing Guide.*

Connection over perfection.

How to look natural and feel completely yourselves.

Why posing is a skill — and how we teach it.

The fundamentals of couple posing.

Walking, movement & the in-between moments.

Standing, sitting & ground poses.

What to do with your hands.

Expressions, eyes & genuine connection.

How your session actually flows.

E

WELCOME

Nobody Is Born Knowing

How to Pose for Photos.

"The stiffness you feel at the start? Completely normal. It never lasts. We know exactly how to get you past it."

Almost every couple we photograph arrives slightly nervous. Almost every couple we photograph walks away with images they love. The difference is what happens in the first fifteen minutes — and what we do to get you there.

Engagement posing isn't about striking the perfect position. It's about creating a framework for genuine connection, then capturing what happens within it. The best images almost always come from between the poses — when you're laughing, adjusting, looking away and back.

We guide everything. You never have to wonder what to do next. Read this once before your session, and you'll arrive knowing the fundamentals. The rest, we'll find together.

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ENGAGEMENT SESSIONS

Posing is our job. You just show up.

01

Connection Over Perfection.

Before we talk about a single pose, there's something more important. The couples who have the best sessions aren't the ones who pose perfectly — they're the ones who stay focused on each other instead of the camera.

THE MINDSET THAT CHANGES EVERYTHING WITHIN A GUIDE YOU

+ Focus on your partner, not the camera.

When you look at each other instead of the lens, your body language softens, your expressions become genuine, and everything feels more natural. The best images almost never come from staring straight at the camera.

+ Movement relaxes you.

Standing perfectly still and holding a pose is where tension lives. Walking, shifting weight, swaying, adjusting — any movement helps your body relax. We almost always begin with movement for this reason.

+ The in-between moments are the images.

Mid-laugh. Mid-adjustment. The second after a kiss. Looking away and then back. These transitions are where genuine expression lives. Poses are the starting point — not the destination.

+ It takes about fifteen minutes.

Almost every couple feels slightly stiff at the start. Almost every couple relaxes within fifteen minutes. We build sessions around this rhythm. Your only job is to trust the process and stay present with each other.

+ We direct everything.

Where to stand, how to angle your bodies, where to look, what to do with your hands. You will never be left standing there wondering what to do next. If something feels off, just say so.

+ We use prompts, not poses.

Instead of placing you in a position and telling you to hold it, we give you something to do: whisper something in her ear. Walk toward us and talk. Tell her the first thing you noticed about her. The response is always real.

+ We're watching things you're not.

Light, angle, where your hands are, how you're standing relative to each other. While you're focused on each other, we're managing every technical detail so the result looks effortless.

+ Perfection isn't the goal.

The best engagement images don't look posed. They look like a window into your actual relationship. The closer we get to capturing that, the better the images. That's what we're after.

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Focus on each other. We'll handle everything else.

02

The Fundamentals.

These principles apply to almost every position — standing, sitting, moving. Understanding them before you arrive means you warm up faster and feel more confident from the first frame.

FOR BOTH OF YOU

- + **Get closer than feels natural.**
On camera, space feels bigger than it looks in real life. What feels like crowding each other reads as warm, comfortable closeness on camera. When in doubt, close the gap. We'll tell you when you're there.
- + **Touch points make all the difference.**
Instead of just holding hands, intertwine your fingers completely. Instead of an arm around the waist, pull in close. Genuine contact creates warmth that posed-looking touch can never replicate.
- + **Breathe. Right before the shutter.**
Take a breath and let half of it out just before we shoot. Shoulders drop, expression softens, jaw relaxes. It's a small reset that makes a visible difference in every frame.
- + **Relax your shoulders actively.**
Tension lives in the shoulders first. Before every setup, consciously drop them down and back. This one physical reset changes your posture, your expression, and the energy of the image.

HER FUNDAMENTALS

- + **The chin trick.**
Push your chin slightly forward and down. This defines the jawline, eliminates double-chin shadows, and makes the neck look longer. Practice in a mirror — it feels unnatural and photographs beautifully.
- + **Shift your weight.**
Equal weight on both feet looks rigid. Shift to one leg, let the hip drop naturally. Suddenly you have shape, angle, and personality. Do this in every standing pose.
- + **Turn your body, keep your face toward us.**
Turn your shoulders 30-45 degrees away from the camera while keeping your face toward it. This creates dimension and a more flattering silhouette. We'll find your stronger side in the first few minutes.

HIS FUNDAMENTALS

- + **Strong, confident lines.**
Stand slightly at an angle, not straight-on. Weight distributed but intentional. Shoulders back. Men's poses benefit from strong, clear lines — avoid slouching or crossing arms defensively.
- + **Give your hands a job.**
Hands in pockets, one thumb hooked in a belt loop, arm around her waist, hand at her back. Flat hands hanging at your sides look uncertain on camera. Always give them a reason to be where they are.

PRACTICE BEFORE YOU ARRIVE

Chin forward and down · Weight shift · Shoulder drop · Close the gap between you.

03

Movement & Walking.

Movement is the fastest way to relax. We almost always begin here. Walking, swaying, spinning — the moment your body starts moving, the stiffness disappears and the genuine expressions begin.

POSE 1

Walk toward us.

Hold hands and walk naturally toward the camera — not performing walking, just actually walking. Eyes on each other or off to the side. This single prompt creates more usable images than almost any other.

1

POSE 2

Walk away and look back.

Walk away from us, then turn to look back over one shoulder. The twist creates a beautiful diagonal through the frame. Walk slowly, let it be natural. The looking-back moment is almost always the frame.

2

POSE 3

Slow dance, no music.

Face each other, close the gap, and sway. Not choreographed — just the feeling of a slow dance. We'll give you prompts: whisper something, close your eyes, look down and then up. Pure gold every time.

3

POSE 4

The spin.

He takes her hand and spins her slowly. She can let the dress fly or keep it contained. Commitment is everything — a half-committed twirl reads as awkward. A fully committed one reads as effortless.

4

POSE 5

Walk side by side.

Shoulders touching, hands linked or arms intertwined. Eyes forward, toward each other, or toward us. Changing this small detail creates significant variety from a single setup.

5

POSE 6

The in-between.

The seconds between one setup and the next — when you're adjusting, laughing, resetting — we're still shooting. Some of the most natural images in every gallery come from exactly these moments.

6

THE MOVEMENT TRUTH

Don't perform the movement. Just do it. Walking like you're actually walking, dancing because it feels good, laughing because something is funny — these always look better than doing those things 'for the camera.' The camera is very good at telling the difference. Be in the moment. We catch it.

04

Standing Together.

Standing poses show your full outfits and create the most polished, elevated images of the session. The key: get close, angle toward each other, and give every limb a reason to be where it is.

POSE 7

Face-to-face.

Stand facing each other, close the gap until it feels like too much, and look into each other's eyes. Touch foreheads. Or look down together. Or go in for a slow kiss. Incredibly versatile starting point.

7

POSE 8

The classic embrace.

She faces the camera, he wraps his arms around her from behind, chin resting on her shoulder or lips at her temple. Look at us, look at each other, or close your eyes. Every variation works.

8

POSE 9

Facing the same direction.

Stand side by side facing the same way — the scene ahead of you, a view, a backdrop. Shoulders together, hands held or arms linked. A different dynamic than face-to-face. More contemplative, equally beautiful.

9

POSE 10

The lean.

One of you leans against a wall, post, or tree. The other leans in. Creates a relaxed, editorial quality. Play with who leans and who's leaning in — both versions work.

10

POSE 11

The dip.

A gentle dip — not dramatic, just romantic. Works best when it grows naturally from dancing rather than being set up cold. The laughing version is often more beautiful than the serious one.

11

POSE 12

Forehead to forehead.

Close together, foreheads touching, eyes down or closed. Quietly intimate. No talking required. This is where you feel the image more than see it. Works in any location, any light.

12

STANDING TIPS

+ Angle your bodies toward each other.

Facing straight-on is almost never the most flattering angle for either of you. Even a small angle toward each other creates dimension and visual interest in the frame.

+ She stands slightly in front of him.

For many setups, having her slightly in front and him slightly behind creates a natural layering that reads beautifully. We'll guide you into this without it feeling contrived.

05

Sitting & Ground Poses.

Sitting and ground poses are often where the session turns a corner. Lower energy, easier to relax into, and they create a completely different visual feel from standing images. Every gallery needs both.

POSE 13

Steps & ledges.

Sit together on steps, a ledge, or a low wall. Lean into each other. Crossed ankles for elegance. Elbows on knees for casual. The environment becomes part of the image.

13

POSE 14

Ground sit facing.

Sit facing each other on the ground, legs angled to the side or crossed. Lean in close. Hold hands between you. One of the most intimate setups in the session.

14

POSE 15

Ground sit side by side.

Both sit on the ground leaning into each other. One rests their head on the other's shoulder. Natural, relaxed, completely genuine. Works beautifully in any natural outdoor location.

15

POSE 16

She sits, he stands.

She sits on a step, ledge, or low surface while he stands behind or beside her. Creates a beautiful height dynamic and a different relational energy than sitting side by side.

16

POSE 17

Legs extended.

One or both sit with legs extended forward. Natural lean, one arm propped behind. A long, relaxed silhouette. Works best on grass or a clean outdoor surface.

17

POSE 18

Knees up, looking away.

Sit with knees pulled up, arms resting lightly on them, looking off into the distance or back over one shoulder. Contemplative, genuine, and enduringly timeless.

18

SITTING TIPS

The ground is your friend. Don't worry about grass stains or getting dirty — that's what editing is for. The couples who fully commit to sitting on the ground, leaning in, and letting themselves be there — those sessions produce the most genuine images. In sitting poses: lean slightly forward, cross your ankles, and get close enough that it feels like too much.

06

Hands, Details & The Ring.

Hands tell as much of the story as faces do. They show connection, tenderness, and personality. And the ring deserves its own moment — planned, intentional, and beautifully lit.

WHAT TO DO WITH YOUR HANDS THE RING SHOTS

+ Intertwine your fingers fully.

Don't just hold hands — intertwine your fingers completely. Full contact creates warmth and visual interest that a casual loose handhold can't replicate.

+ His hand at her back or waist.

A hand placed intentionally at the small of her back, at her waist, or cupping her face reads as protective, tender, and completely natural. One of the most consistently beautiful hand placements in couple photography.

+ Her hand at his chest or shoulder.

One hand resting lightly on his chest, at his shoulder, or around his neck during a close moment. Draws them together and gives her hands a clear, elegant purpose.

+ Hands touching faces.

His hands cupping her face before a kiss. Her hand at his jaw. These close-contact moments create some of the most intimate and emotionally powerful images of any engagement session.

+ Let hands relax naturally.

When hands are at your sides, keep fingers slightly curved — not stiff, not fully open. A loose, natural curve is almost invisible on camera. Rigid or flat hands read as tense.

+ Clean the ring before the session.

A clean ring catches light beautifully. A dirty ring looks dull on camera regardless of how stunning it is in person. Clean it the night before with warm water and a soft brush.

+ Hands together, ring featured.

Both hands stacked together with the ring facing the camera. Simple and classic. Works as a wide shot showing the couple and as a close-up detail image.

+ Her hand on his, ring on top.

Her hand resting on his with the ring facing up toward the light. One of the most naturally beautiful ring shots because it reads as genuinely intimate rather than posed for display.

+ Close-up detail shots.

We step in close and isolate the ring — on her finger, held between their fingers, against a texture. These detail images anchor the gallery and work beautifully for announcements.

+ Ring against meaningful details.

Her ring against the lapel of his jacket. Against the texture of a wooden surface or a stone wall. Against a flower. Environmental ring shots add a storytelling quality to the gallery.

Tell us before the session if there's a particular ring shot you love. We plan for detail shots as a standard part of every engagement session — but if you have something specific in mind, the more we know, the better.

07

Expressions & Eyes.

Expression is the difference between a portrait and a photograph. Your faces tell the story. Eyes especially — where you look and what you're feeling shapes every image.

EXPRESSION TYPES

- + **The real laugh.**
We earn this. A prompt, a joke, something we say that catches you off guard. Real laughter is the most valuable thing in any engagement gallery — and it cannot be faked. When it comes, don't suppress it.
- + **The soft smile.**
Slightly upturned lips, relaxed jaw, eyes soft. Not a full grin — somewhere between neutral and smiling. This is often the expression in the image that gets printed and framed. Practice it in a mirror.
- + **Neutral and present.**
No smile. Eyes forward or toward each other. Relaxed jaw. Reads as editorial, intimate, and emotionally powerful. Many couples feel like they look stern. They never do. This is often one of the most beautiful frames.
- + **The almost-kiss.**
Lips an inch apart, eyes closed or nearly closed, forehead together. The anticipation reads as incredibly romantic on camera — sometimes even more so than the kiss itself.

WHERE TO LOOK

- + **At each other — always our first choice.**
When you look at each other, the connection between you becomes visible on camera. This is where the most emotionally powerful images come from. We use this most.
- + **At the camera — for connection with the viewer.**
Looking directly into the lens creates images that feel like they're looking at whoever views them — for the rest of their life. Powerful for the images that will be framed and gifted.
- + **Off to the side — candid and contemplative.**
Looking completely past the camera creates a candid, lifestyle quality. Especially beautiful in movement shots and as variety within any single setup.
- + **Down, then up on cue.**
Eyes down, then slowly lifted toward us or toward each other on our cue. The moment your gaze comes up is almost always where the most genuine expression lives.

PROMPTS WE USE TO EARN REAL EXPRESSIONS

- Whisper the first thing you noticed about each other.
- Tell her the thing you're most excited about for your wedding day.
- Make each other laugh without making a sound.
- Look at each other like you haven't seen each other in a week.

08

Your Session, Your Way.

Here's how a Nydam Photography engagement session actually flows — so you know exactly what to expect when you arrive and nothing feels like a surprise.

WHEN YOU ARRIVE

We ease in. There's no jumping straight into formal poses — the first 10-15 minutes are always a warmup. Walking, adjusting, getting comfortable in the space. The camera is running. By the time the real direction begins, you've already forgotten to be stiff.

HOW WE GUIDE YOU

Every position, every angle, every expression is guided with intention. You'll always know where to stand, where to look, and what to do with your hands. If something feels off, say so. We'd rather find what works than have you hold anything uncomfortable.

OUTFIT CHANGES

If you're bringing two looks, we plan the flow around the change. We'll find a comfortable, private spot and time it naturally. Touch up your lips, reset your hair, take a breath. Each look gets its own energy.

THE SECOND HALF

This is where the best images almost always come from. You're warmed up, relaxed, and no longer thinking about what your faces are doing. The session stops feeling like a session. We're still working — but it doesn't feel like it anymore.

GALLERY DELIVERY

You'll receive a private, password-protected gallery of fully edited, high-resolution images. Ready to print, frame, and use for your save-the-dates. Questions about products or usage? Just reply.

"These poses are starting points — not a checklist. We adapt to who you are. The goal is images that look unmistakably like the two of you."

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

nydamphoto.com · arlen.nydam@gmail.com